valley of Khyber, which is in the possession of the Khyberis, my subjects, has greatly angered these people who will of course do what they can to prevent it,' he wrote to Ranjit Singh's General, Hari Singh, the leader of the Sikh forces in Peshawar. 'My son Mohammad Akbar Khan will also do everything in his power to assist them . . . If you will exert yourself with the Maharaja to restore Peshawar to me, I will not fail to send him horses & other presents from the produce of this country. In the event of you effecting this object, I will agree to whatever you propose. If not, you know my response.'[40]

The Sikhs ignored the warning. Two months later, soon after Ranjit Singh had withdrawn his elite European-trained force, the Fauj-i-Khas, so that they could be guards of honour at a royal wedding in Lahore, 20,000 Afghan cavalry descended the Khyber, and on 30 April succeeded in surrounding Hari Singh near the walls of the new fort at Jamrud. According to the *Siraj ul-Tawarikh*, 'In the heat of the furious combat, Akbar Khan encountered Hari Singh. Without recognising each other, they exchanged blows and after much thrusting and parrying, Akbar Khan won out, knocking Hari Singh to the ground, and killing him. With their commander dead and the army of Islam rolling towards them like a tide in flood, the Sikhs abandoned the field. They were pursued by the sardars as far as Jamrud Fort where they barricaded themselves inside.'[41] The Fauj-i-Khas quickly turned around and a fortnight later drove off the besieging Afghans; but it was a huge boost to the prestige of Dost Mohammad and the first great victory of Akbar Khan, demonstrating how far he had inherited his father's military talents. From this point he would increasingly become the most formidable Afghan commander.

Burnes was halfway up the Indus when he heard of the battle. For a time, it was unclear whether the hostilities would block his route into Afghanistan and bring about the cancellation of his mission. Either way, he realised the fighting would put the British in the awkward position of trying to remain allies of both sides in a war. But by the time Burnes had reached Peshawar and saw the difficulties the Sikhs were having holding the province and that they had found it 'impossible to keep the country in order', he became convinced that the occupation was proving so troublesome and expensive for the Sikhs that it left him ample room to negotiate a solution. In a letter to John MacNeill in Teheran, he mulled over the idea of an agreement